Acne and Pimples

A practical guide to gentle skin care and treatment conversations

ABOUT THIS TOPIC

Acne can cause blackheads, whiteheads, inflamed spots, and deeper tender bumps. It often affects the face, chest, shoulders, or back. Picking or squeezing can increase inflammation and the risk of lasting marks.

Everyday care and treatment

- Wash gently up to twice daily and after sweating. Avoid scrubs, harsh toners, and repeated washing.
- Choose products labeled non-comedogenic when possible. Remove makeup before sleep and avoid picking spots.
- For mild acne, some people use one over-the-counter ingredient such as benzoyl peroxide, adapalene, azelaic acid, or salicylic acid. Start one product at a time and follow its label; irritation can occur.
- Give a routine several weeks to work. A clinician can advise which products are suitable, especially during pregnancy or breastfeeding.

WHEN TO GET HELP

Arrange a clinical review for painful deep bumps, scarring, widespread acne, significant distress, or acne that has not improved with careful over-the-counter use. Seek urgent help for a severe allergic reaction to a product.

Sources for further reading

American Academy of Dermatology - Acne skin care tips - https://www.aad.org/public/diseases/acne/skin-care/tips

American Academy of Dermatology - Acne treatment - https://www.aad.org/public/diseases/acne/derm-treat/treat

American Academy of Dermatology - Adult acne treatment - https://www.aad.org/public/diseases/acne/diy/adult-acne-treatment

Reviewed for this educational handout: October 2026. Recommendations can change and depend on local guidance, age, pregnancy, other health conditions, and medicines. This handout is not a diagnosis or prescription.